# PHP Security Update Guide

Skywave Website — upgrading PHP on cPanel to fix CVE-2026-109618 and CVE-2026-109619

Prepared: 26 October 2026 | Repository: skywave/skywave-website | Branch: skywave-desktop

## 1. The short version

There is a serious security flaw in the software that runs our website (PHP). An attacker could use it to take control of the server that hosts the website, without needing a password.

The organisation that makes PHP released a fix on 21 October 2026. Security agencies around the world (CISA, CERT-EU, NCSC) are advising everyone to update immediately.

> **In one sentence:** We need to switch the website's PHP version to a fixed release. It is a settings change in cPanel and takes about five minutes.

## 2. What has already been done

- **Code check:** we reviewed the website's code. It works correctly with the fixed PHP versions — nothing needs to be rewritten.
- **Temporary protection:** a request-size limit was added to the website configuration, which makes one of the attacks harder. This is a stop-gap, not the real fix.
- **Instructions:** this document, plus a technical note (`SECURITY.md`) in the repository.

## 3. What still needs to happen

Someone with the **cPanel login** (the website hosting account) must switch the website to a fixed PHP version. The safe versions are:

| PHP version | Status |
|---|---|
| 8.5.12 | Fixed |
| 8.4.27 | Fixed |
| 8.3.36 | Fixed — recommended |
| 8.2.35 | Fixed (minimum) |
| 8.1 and older | No longer supported — must be upgraded |

**Note:** these flaws are inside PHP itself. They cannot be fixed from the GitHub repository. Only a PHP upgrade on the hosting server removes the risk.

## 4. Step-by-step in cPanel

These steps are for whoever holds the cPanel account. No programming is involved.

### Step 1 — Log in to cPanel

Open the cPanel address provided by the hosting company. It usually looks like `https://[DOMAIN]/cpanel` or comes from the hosting provider's client area. Enter the username and password.

### Step 2 — Open the PHP tool

In the *Software* section, look for **MultiPHP Manager**. Some hosts call it **Select PHP Version**. You can also type “PHP” in the search box at the top of cPanel.

### Step 3 — Select the website

A list of domains will appear. Tick the box next to the domain that runs our website: [DOMAIN]

### Step 4 — Change the PHP version

- **MultiPHP Manager:** in the “PHP Version” dropdown choose **8.3**, then click **Apply**.
- **Select PHP Version:** open the **PHP** tab, choose **8.3**, and make sure the boxes for `mysqli`, `mail` and `openssl` are ticked. Then save.

If 8.3 is not listed, choose 8.4 or 8.2 instead — as long as it is 8.2.35 or newer.

### Step 5 — Confirm the version

The domain list should now show the new version. The exact number should be **8.3.36** or higher (or the matching 8.4 / 8.5 patch level).

### Step 6 — Quick technical check (optional)

Create a file named `version-check.php` in the website's main folder containing exactly this line:

```
<?php echo PHP_VERSION; ?>
```

Open `https://[DOMAIN]/version-check.php` in a browser. It should show a version such as `8.3.36`. **Delete the file immediately afterwards.**

### Step 7 — Test the website

Open the website and submit the booking form. You should see the “Thank you, your booking has been received” message, and the confirmation email should arrive.

### Step 8 — If something goes wrong

Nothing is permanent. Go back to MultiPHP Manager, select the previous PHP version, and click Apply. The website returns to how it was.

## 5. If you do not have the cPanel login

Send the message below to the person or company who manages the hosting account:

> **Subject:** Urgent — patch PHP for CVE-2026-109618 / CVE-2026-109619
>
> On 21 October 2026 the PHP project disclosed two critical unauthenticated remote code execution vulnerabilities, CVE-2026-109618 and CVE-2026-109619 (severity 9.2, known as “php2shell”). They affect all PHP versions from 5.4 through 8.5.11, including PHP-FPM and mod_php. CISA and CERT-EU recommend patching internet-facing systems immediately.
>
> Please upgrade the PHP version serving the Skywave website to one of:
>
> - PHP 8.5.12
> - PHP 8.4.27
> - PHP 8.3.36
> - PHP 8.2.35
>
> PHP 8.1 and older are end-of-life and will not be patched, so 8.2.35 or newer is required. The website code has been reviewed and is compatible with PHP 8.2 to 8.5; no application changes are needed. After the upgrade, please confirm the active version so we can run verification tests.

## 6. References

- PHP security releases: https://www.php.net/archive/2026.php
- CISA alert: https://www.cisa.gov/news-events/alerts/2026/10/21/critical-vulnerabilities-php-require-immediate-patching
- CERT-EU advisory: https://www.cert.europa.eu/publications/security-advisories/2026-018/

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